

GODS AND TEMPLES

For most of their long history, the Romans believed in many gods and goddesses. These powerful beings were thought to watch over and control every aspect of daily life. As long as people worshipped the gods, then good things would happen. To make sure of this, people offered gifts to the gods in their homes and at temples.

Houses for the gods

Roman temples were houses for the gods to live in. Don't think of them as being like churches, synagogues, or mosques—because they weren't. While people today worship inside religious buildings, the Romans performed their acts of devotion outside the temples, at altars nearby. The inside of a Roman temple was dark and virtually

empty except for the statue of the god whose temple it was. People believed that the god's spirit lived inside the statue.

Gifts great and small

People sought favors from the gods. In repayment, they

BEFORE THE SACRIFICE OF A BULL, A PRIEST IS SHOWN PURIFYING THE AIR BY BURNING SWEET-SMELLING INCENSE ON A FIRE.

